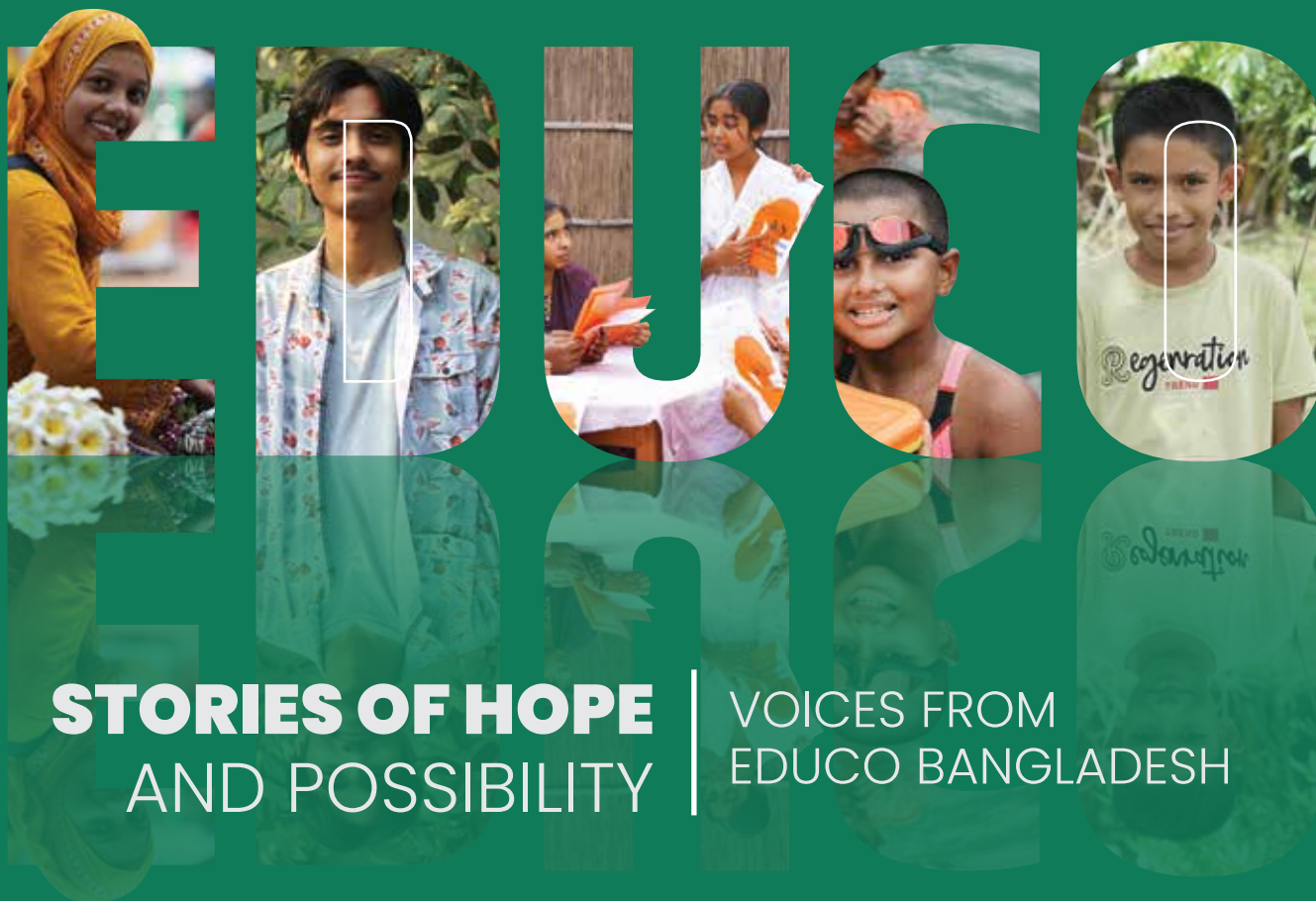




STORIES OF HOPE
AND POSSIBILITY

VOICES FROM
EDUCO BANGLADESH

Country Director's Message

It is with great pride that I present this collection of human stories — stories of resilience, courage, and the extraordinary strength that lives within every child and young person. At Educo Bangladesh, we believe that every child has the right to learn, grow, and thrive in an environment of dignity and safety. This book is a reflection of that belief, brought to life through the voices of those whose journeys inspire our mission.

Each story in this publication opens a window into a world where possibilities conquer over hardships. Here, you will meet young children taking their first steps into learning, adolescents challenging harmful norms, youth courageously shaping their identities, and caregivers rebuilding their lives with hope. Their stories remind us that change does not always begin with grand gestures — sometimes it starts with a safe classroom, a supportive mentor, a caring community space, or simply the belief that “I can.” Behind these transformations is the caring and committed efforts of our implementing partners, donors, caregivers, teachers, and community members. Your dedication strengthens our programmes and ensures that our work does more than provide services — it ignites hope, expands opportunities, and builds resilience for generations to come.



At Educo Bangladesh, we remain committed to creating environments where children and young people are seen, heard, and empowered. The challenges they face — poverty, inequality, violence, and displacement — are immense. Yet time and again, they have shown us what becomes possible when they receive the support they deserve. Their achievements motivate us to continue strengthening our work in education, child protection, youth empowerment, climate resilience, and skills development.

I extend my deepest gratitude to all who contributed to bringing these stories to life — to the children and youth who shared experiences with honesty and courage; to our partners and project teams whose firm commitment made these journeys possible; and to our donors for trusting our vision.

May these stories renew our collective commitment to building a world where every child's rights are protected, their dreams nurtured, and their potential fully realised. Let us continue to work together — boldly, compassionately, and tirelessly — so that hope becomes not the exception, but the everyday reality for every child in Bangladesh.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Hamid'.

Abdul Hamid
Country Director
Educo Bangladesh

Editorial

Every child has a story — a tale of dreams, struggles, and the courage to overcome challenges. Stories remind us why we work: to create opportunities for every child and young person to learn, grow, and live with dignity.

This booklet gathers real-life stories from across our programmes — featuring children, adolescents, youth, and caregivers whose lives have been touched by Educo and its partners. From classrooms to youth clubs, tea gardens to refugee camps, these voices reflect determination, creativity, and the transformative power of education, protection, and empowerment.

Behind each story stands a network of dedicated partners, donors, caregivers, and community members whose collective efforts make meaningful change possible. Together, we are not just responding to needs; we are nurturing hope, building resilience, and empowering the next generation to dream bigger and stand out in every storm.

We extend our heartfelt gratitude to all the children and youth who courageously shared their journeys, to our implementing partners for their commitment, and to our donors for believing in our mission.

May these stories inspire us all to continue working towards a world where every child's right to education, protection, and participation is not merely a vision, but a reality.

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Disclaimer

The stories featured in this booklet are based on real experiences of children, adolescents, youth, and caregivers who have participated in Educo Bangladesh's programmes and projects implemented in collaboration with partner organisations. The views expressed herein should not be taken in any way to reflect the official opinion of Educo Bangladesh. The publisher (Educo Bangladesh) holds the copyright, but text and photos may be reproduced for non-profit purpose. Prior permission is encouraged for such use.

Table of content

SHUVOSREE BLOSSOMS WITH CARE AND SUPPORT	06
SAGOR'S LIFELINE IS HIS SCHOOL	11
CHALLENGES NEVER BROKE MONJILA'S HOPE	17
PARVEZ'S JOURNEY TOWARDS BETTER EDUCATION	21
DEEN NEVER COMPROMISES WITH SOCIAL TABOOS	25
AYESHA IS THE TRAILBLAZER	31
YEASIN'S JOURNEY TO SPREAD BENGALI FLAVOURS WORLDWIDE	35
JANNAT STANDS AGAINST CHILD MARRIAGE	39
THE STORY OF A GIRL WHO TURNED WOOD INTO JEWELRY	43
FROM CAMP 17, NOOR HOPES TO HEAL HER COMMUNITY	49

A woman with a pink shirt and orange sari is smiling and hugging a young girl in a blue shirt. The girl is also smiling. They are positioned in front of a green background with a faint leaf pattern.

SHUVOSREE BLOSSOMS WITH CARE AND SUPPORT



Shuvosree Khoyra
Student, Early Childhood
Development Centre

A young girl with dark hair, wearing a green and red patterned dress, is sitting on the ground. She is looking down at something in her hands. In the background, there is a pile of dry leaves and a white cloth.

Five-year-old Shuvosree Khoyra from Mirzapur Tea Garden in Moulvibazar faced a challenging start in life. In 2019, her father, Bulbul Khoyra, died of a cardiac arrest, leaving the family without its sole breadwinner. Her mother, Usha Khoyra, suddenly had to shoulder the responsibility of raising two children alone. With no other support in this difficult time, Usha took up a temporary job as a tea leaf picker, but her meager income was not enough to ensure her children's health and well-being.

In June 2022, when Shuvosree was only three years old, a caregiver visited her home and observed that she was extremely weak, exhausted, and visibly malnourished. Soon after, she was enrolled in a nearby Early Childhood Development (ECD) centre with Day Care facilities, with the support of her mother and grandmother. The centre, implemented by Multipurpose Socio Economic Development Association (MSEDA) under the ALOY-ALLOW project and funded by ChildFund Korea, became a vital source of care and support for Shuvosree.



Usha recalls, **“We did not have proper knowledge. I was always concerned about balancing my work with caring for my children. Shuvosree’s admission has helped me relax. ALOY-ALLOW has been a big support.”**

At first, Shuvosree found it hard to adjust—she couldn’t walk properly, spoke unclearly, and was very shy. However, the caregivers gave her special attention, involved her in playful activities, and ensured she received nutritious snacks daily. After a year, Shuvosree has shown remarkable progress. She plays with friends, eats well, and has become more confident.





SAGOR'S LIFELINE IS HIS SCHOOL



Md. Sagor Mollah

Student and Child Labour
ODHIKAR Pathshala



At just eight years old, I began collecting garbage, earning only BDT 50–80 a day — barely enough to buy some rice.

“Sometimes I don’t want to work as a garbage collector because of the smell, and I often hurt myself with the sharp things people throw away. One day, I cut my leg so badly that it needed two stitches, and I had to stay in bed for a whole week. However, I have no choice. I must work to earn some money. What hurts me most is that we don’t even have soap at home. I can’t clean myself properly or wash my only shirt.”



In 2023, my life changed when I was admitted to ODHIKAR Pathshala, supported by Educo Bangladesh and ChildFund Korea. Starting in grade two, I discovered a world where I could learn, play, and eat a warm meal — often my only food of the day.

“I dream of becoming a skilled driver, caring for my mother, educating my nephew, and helping other fatherless children like me.”



Hoping for a better future, my mother and sister went to Saudi Arabia, but traffickers trapped them. They suffered abuse and returned home with trauma. My mother became seriously ill, and my sister was abandoned with a child. Still a little boy, I became the only earning member of the family, collecting garbage and working dangerously as a laguna helper.



My life is filled with hardship, yet I still dream of a better future. I was born in the slum area of Shaymoli Housing in Dhaka. When I was only three months old, my father left our family and remarried. My mother, Aleya Parvin, tried to continue working as a domestic worker, but with two small children, it soon became impossible. Eventually, I was forced to beg to survive.



CHALLENGES NEVER BROKE MONJILA'S HOPE



Monjila

Garments Worker
Texeurop BD Ltd.

When my son, Shuyaeb was born, my world changed completely. I had dreamed of raising my child in a safe, happy home, but soon after his birth, my marriage broke into emotional and physical abuse. Eventually, my husband divorced me, leaving me alone in Dhaka city with a newborn and no support.

"I was scared, not just for me and my child. I had no one. I used to cry quietly every night, wondering what would happen to us."

Determined to survive, I found work at Texeurop BD Ltd., however, life was far from easy. Each day, I left my baby with a neighbour, paying BDT 4000 every month. Though I worked hard, my heart was heavy with fear about my child's safety. ***"I often thought about quitting. But quitting meant hunger, debt, and an uncertain future."***



Everything changed when I found out about the day care centre inside my factory, supported by the SMILE Project. **"Here, the caregivers take special care of my son along with other children by providing nutritious food, bathing them, playing with them, and helping them sleep. They even arrange parenting sessions for mothers like me so that we can learn how to take proper care of our children."** For the first time, I found a safe and caring place for my son.



"The first day I left Shuyaeb at the daycare, I cried on the way to work—not from fear, but relief. I could finally work in peace knowing he was safe."

With my child safe, I began focusing entirely on my job. My performance improved, I started saving money, and most importantly, I regained hope. **"Now, I truly believe I can give my son a better life. I want him to go to school, chase his dream, and never experience the fear I once felt."**





PARVEZ'S JOURNEY TOWARDS BETTER EDUCATION



Parvez Hossen
Student
Sidly Government Primary School



I am Md. Parvez Hossen, a class five student at Sidly Government Primary School (GPS). Life has not been easy—over ten years ago, my father lost his sight to glaucoma, leaving my mother, a homemaker, to carry the family's struggles alone.



Since I often assist my mother with household chores, continuing my studies has been challenging, which once held me back in class. But in 2021, a new light entered my life through the ESDO-Educo project. Through the guidance and care of teachers at the Community-Based Learning Centre (CBLC) under this project, I gradually transformed into a confident, attentive student. I now enjoy both academic and co-curricular activities, and my love for learning grows stronger every day.



"I always wanted to study, but our struggles made it seem impossible." Today, that dream feels within reach. My teacher, Md. Jahangir Alom has made mathematics my favourite subject, while assistant teacher Lovely Akter praises my steady progress.

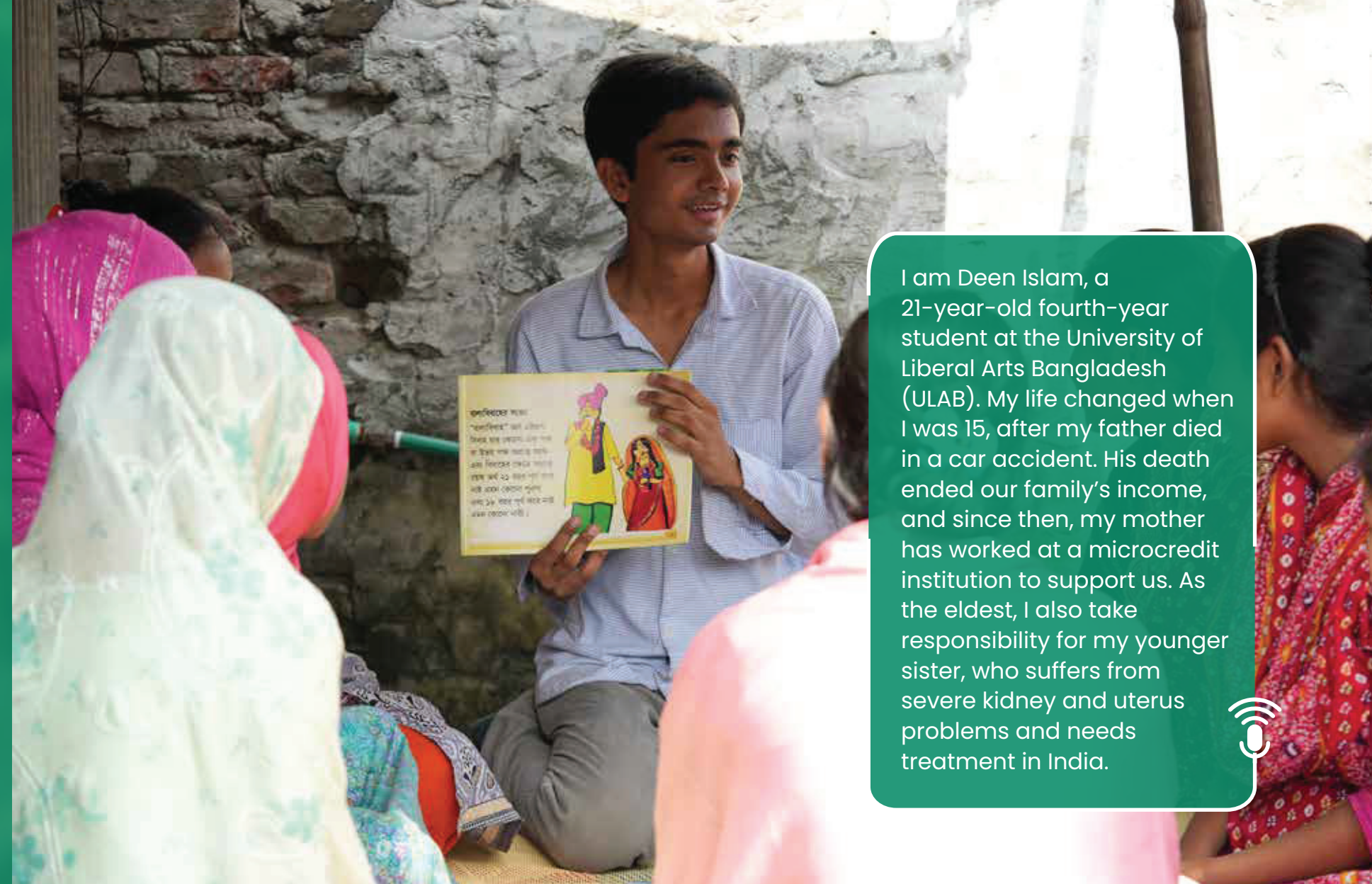
Besides doing studies, I enjoy playing football, cricket, and especially badminton with my school friends. My mother, Mst. Pervin Akter hopes that I will complete my education and contribute positively to society.

DEEN NEVER COMPROMISES WITH SOCIAL TABOOS



Din Islam

Member
Child Protection Committee



I am Deen Islam, a 21-year-old fourth-year student at the University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (ULAB). My life changed when I was 15, after my father died in a car accident. His death ended our family's income, and since then, my mother has worked at a microcredit institution to support us. As the eldest, I also take responsibility for my younger sister, who suffers from severe kidney and uterus problems and needs treatment in India.



Growing up, I began to express my femininity and faced constant bullying and discrimination in school, college, and even within my community in Kadamtali, Dhaka. Despite these barriers, I continued my education with the dream of building a better future for my family.

In 2022, I joined the Educo project club, implemented by Nari Maitree. This was a turning point in my life. I became involved with the Kadamtali Kishore Kishori and Jubo Club and, in 2023, joined the Child Protection Committee. Through training, I learned about life skills, non-violent masculinity, and child protection, which inspired me to stand against violence and discrimination.



"I would have stopped my journey because of social barriers, but with the help of Nari Maitree and Educo Bangladesh, I'm moving forward."

Now, I lead awareness plays on child marriage, girls' education, and child rights. I even stopped the marriage of a 14-year-old girl named Borsha. Additionally, I supported children who had dropped out of school in returning to education. I also work with the Directorate of Social Services to advocate for the rights of gender-diverse people and children like me.



“Joining the Educo club opened doors of possibilities for me to learn and advocate for positive change.”

“My dream is to study filmmaking at Shantiniketan and one day establish a school for gender diverse people, where we can learn and grow with dignity.” I believe, “Every child in our community deserves their basic rights.”



AYESHA IS THE TRAILBLAZER



Ayesha Tabassum Saba
Swimmer



Saba, an eight-year-old, is a talented swimmer whose dream is vast like an ocean. The eldest of three siblings, Saba, comes from a family that loves sports. Her father and mother are both black belts in Karate and Judo. Though they once dreamed of representing Bangladesh internationally, life's responsibilities halted their journey. However, they instill their ambitions into their children.



From an early age, Saba showed an extraordinary fascination with water. While her peers played in the fields, she spent time near ponds, copying the strokes she saw on television. Her father noticed her interest and decided to guide her and became her first coach. With minimal resources, however, her parents nurtured her talent with extreme dedication.

Her turning point came when she joined Educo's **"Game Changer"** project, implemented by the Sachetan Society in Rajshahi. Through the project, she received swimming equipment and sportswear, which made her training smoother and more focused. Now, she trains two hours daily at the Rajshahi District Swimming Pool while balancing her studies. In **2025**, she competed in the **Dhaka National Swimming Competition**, entering six events and winning **three gold and two silver medals**.

Her teachers and friends admire Saba for her kindness, discipline, and determination. Despite her success, she remains humble and focused. **"One day, I want to swim in the Olympics and bring honour to my country,"** she says. Saba also dreams of becoming a marine engineer and serving in the Bangladesh Navy.





YEASIN'S JOURNEY TO SPREAD BENGALI FLAVOURS WORLDWIDE



Md Yasin
Junior Chef



I am a 20-year-old youth and the eldest of three siblings. Life has not been easy for me. I grew up in a lower-middle-income family in Feni, where financial struggles were a constant presence. After completing my S.S.C., I moved to Dhaka with the support of my maternal uncle and studied Business Studies for my H.S.C. But after that, I had to stop my education to support my family.



At that time, I learned about the Educo's LIFT Project – Leveraging Youth Employment in Bangladesh Through Improving Their Employability and Competitiveness to Fit with the 21st Century Job Market. This initiative, implemented by Eco-Social Development Organization (ESDO) and funded by ChildFund Korea, offered opportunities for vulnerable youth like me. With encouragement from a friend, I joined the programme.

During career planning meetings, I shared my dream of running a restaurant, inspired by my grandfather, who once owned a small yet famous Bengali eatery. The project team enrolled me in Xinxian Hospitality Training Institute for Food and Beverage Production and Service. I completed 720 hours of training, equally divided between technical and soft skills, over a six-month period. These sessions improved my cooking skills, boosted my confidence, and enhanced my decision-making abilities.



“I used to face challenges while making decisions before. However, after receiving the training, especially the soft skills, my decision-making capacity has increased significantly.” After passing the NSDA assessment, I first worked at Sobuz Pata Resort. Later, I decided to move back to Dhaka for better opportunities. Today, I am working as a junior chef at Chattala Orosh and Mejbani House in Uttara.

“My dream is to become a successful entrepreneur, share Bengali flavours worldwide, and create jobs for young people in my community. I also want to ensure safe drinking water in my locality. For me, success is not just mine—it is for my family and my community.”

JANNAT STANDS AGAINST CHILD MARRIAGE



Jannat

President
Adolescent and Youth Club



I am Jannat, a 19-year-old from Samad Matber Kandi village in Jajira Upazila. I carry strength far beyond my age. Like many girls in my community, I grew up surrounded by expectations that life should follow a predictable path—one that often ends in child marriage, long before dreams have a chance to take flight. But I chose a different one.



"My family believed marriage was the only option for me. But deep inside, I wanted more for myself, for my future, and for other girls like me."

I found a light of hope when I joined the YES4ECO Club under the Youth Environmental Stewardship for Eco-Friendly Communities (YES4ECO) Project. There, I received training not only in environmental stewardship, climate change, and disaster preparedness, but also on child rights and gender equality.



Through these sessions, I found both my voice and my purpose. These trainings encouraged me to speak about my rights and gave me the strength to fight against child marriage for myself.

"The YES4ECO training uplifted my strength. For the first time, I realised I had the right to say 'no' to marriage, to fear, and to silence."

With the support of my club peers and facilitators, I stood firm against pressure to marry at such an early age. I shared what I had learned with my family and community, and with time and dialogue, I helped them see a different future - not just for me, but for many others. Today, I dream of building a better future.

"I want to continue my education, get a good career, and inspire other girls to fight for their rights. I dream of a community where every girl can grow freely and decide her own life."





THE STORY OF A GIRL WHO TURNED WOOD INTO JEWELRY



Anika
Youth Entrepreneur



I am Anika Akter, a 22-year-old living with my mother and my younger sister. While pursuing my second year of honours, I constantly desired to do something creative. That dream inspired me to start a unique business—making wooden jewelry.





One day, I crafted a pair of earrings and a bracelet using old wooden pieces and broken bangles. After sharing the photos on social media, my friends and relatives praised my work and began placing orders. This marked the beginning of my jewelry business, which I pursued alongside my education. Since my father's income alone was not sufficient to cover our family's expenses, this initiative also helped my family. Soon, I expanded to different areas of Dhaka, opened an online page, and participated in handicraft fairs.

Alongside my business, I was also interested in social work. In 2022, with the support of Nari Maitree and funding from Educo, a group of 50 teenagers and youths was formed as part of a project. I became a member of the Katasur Kishor Kishori and Jubo Club. Today, the Club actively engages in community activities. "After joining Nari Maitree, I realised that working together can truly bring change."





Initially, I faced challenges—no startup capital and limited knowledge of online promotion. With Nari Maitree's support, I received initial funding, learned new designs, and improved my production skills. Within a year, my jewelry became popular, and I now earn between BDT 80,000 and BDT 100,000 per month. My work has been recognised at craft fairs and even featured in online news portals.

"Creativity and courage are the main assets of my business. Proving yourself as an entrepreneur can be challenging for women, but it is not impossible. I strive for this every day."

"Now, I dream of providing training other women and showing that with creativity and perseverance, anyone can build their own identity."



FROM CAMP 17, NOOR HOPES TO HEAL HER COMMUNITY



Noor Sahera

Member
Adolescent and Youth Club

I am Noor Sahera, a twelve-year-old girl living with my parents and four siblings in Camp 17, Cox's Bazar. I have spent most of my life here, having fled Myanmar at the age of five. My father, Del Mohammad, works as a construction labourer, while my mother, Fatema Begum, is a homemaker. **"As I was only five during our displacement, I cannot remember much, but I heard it was terrible,"** I recall.



My day begins with Qur'an recitation, followed by school. After returning home, I help my mother with household chores and enjoy playing with my friends. However, I feel the camp lacks safe play areas. **"Our shelter is also at risk of landslides. During the rainy season, we often feel worried because our home is at the foot of a hill, and we fear it might collapse."**

In early 2024, my friends and I joined the Adolescent and Youth (A&Y) Club, a project of Educo, implemented by SKUS, funded by ChildFund New Zealand, and NZMFAT. Through the club, I received training on Child Protection, Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR), Health & Hygiene, and Gender-Based Violence (GBV). **"Now I know how to face disasters and reduce the damage. That's why I am thankful to SKUS."**



I also share my learning with family and neighbours, encouraging them to plant trees to prevent landslides and discouraging hill cutting.

"I even know what to do in case of a fire." I guide children, women, and the elderly to safe spaces during disasters.

"Inspired by my experiences, I want to study hard and become a doctor in the future so I can provide medical care to the people in my community."



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